
UNIT 24

ASL Discourse

Throughout this textbook, we have seen that the different parts of ASL have internal structure. In the phonology section, we saw that signs have parts and that the parts are structured. In the morphology section, we looked at the smallest meaningful units of ASL and talked about how they are used to build new units in the language. In the section on syntax, we saw that ASL sentences are also structured; word order is not random, and nonmanual signals play a very important role in the construction of ASL sentences. So, we have seen that there is structure at each level of the language. But there is more to language than single isolated sentences. People talk to each other, they sign to each other, and they write letters, novels, and newspaper articles. These are all examples of the use of language, and the use of language involves using many sentences.

When people talk or sign or write, the language they use also has structure; that is, words and sentences are not just thrown together in any order. In sociolinguistics, the term *discourse* is used to refer to any use of language that goes beyond the sentence. Discourse can refer to how language is organized in conversations, and it can also refer to how the sentences in a written text, such as a novel or a linguistics textbook, are organized. Language has social functions as well as communicative functions, and, therefore, language is a kind of social behavior. The analysis of discourse has a lot to do with the social functions of language. In this unit, we will provide a brief introduction to discourse analysis and look at some examples of the structure of discourse in ASL.

As explained by sociolinguist R. A. Hudson (1980), the study of discourse involves a number of different areas, four of which we will discuss here — the functions of language, language as skilled work, the norms and structure of language use, and language as a signal of social identity.

THE FUNCTIONS OF LANGUAGE

Language has social functions as well as communicative functions. We do not always use language just to communicate information. Often, language is used to establish

or reinforce social relations or to control the behavior of other people. For example, imagine that you are walking down the street and you see an acquaintance — not someone you know well, not a friend, but someone you recognize — coming toward you. You don't really want to stop and chat, so you keep walking, but as you walk by, you make eye contact and either nod your head or sign a greeting. You may even sign WHAT'S UP and FINE or nod your head as a greeting as you walk by, and the other person may sign the same signs or nod at the same time. The function of language in this situation is not only to exchange information but also to let the other person know that you see him and that you are not ignoring him.

To get a better understanding of the social functions of language, imagine how strange it would be to walk by an acquaintance and not sign anything! If someone you knew walked by you without a greeting, you might think that person was being rude or impolite. That leads us to ask what politeness means. In part, it means recognizing the existence of another person, and the way we accomplish that recognition is with language.

We use language for other social functions as well, such as apologizing, warning, threatening, commanding, and requesting. All of these functions go beyond the purely communicative function of telling someone something she does not already know. In fact, you may sometimes tell someone something she does already know, as a way of controlling behavior. For example, telling someone "it's cold in here," may have the function of requesting that the person close the window. We can also see that discourse varies in a broader sense, depending on its function. That is, the language used in an everyday conversation is different from that used in a classroom lecture, a sermon, or a conference presentation. The language used in stories and poetry has its own structure, as does the language used when an interpreter is present. These are all examples of different genres of discourse.

LANGUAGE AS SKILLED WORK

Some people are very skilled at getting what they want through the use of language, and others are not. Many cultures tend to respect and reward skilled language users; for example, elections can be won or lost depending on a politician's ability to use language. In the American Deaf community, storytellers and poets are recognized and valued not for the content of their work as much as for their skill in the use of ASL. At Deaf social gatherings and parties, people play ABC and number games in ASL, and those who do it well receive the most praise and respect.

THE NORMS AND STRUCTURE OF LANGUAGE USE

Discourse has internal structure and is governed by norms. By norms, we mean how many people can sign at once, how much one person should sign, what topics, if any, are taboo, and so forth. It is easy to identify the norms by looking at examples of norm violations. For example, in a conversation, only one person can sign at a time. If another person begins signing before the first has indicated that he is finished, the second person will be said to have interrupted. The first person may then signal

that he is not finished yet and that the other person should wait his turn. The fact that the second person's behavior is labeled an interruption shows that the norm is "one person signs at a time and when it is clear that he is finished, another person may begin."

Another norm governs the appropriate behavior when walking between two people who are signing to each other. In spoken-language conversations, it is polite to say "excuse me" as you pass. That is, it is appropriate to use language to recognize the fact that you are temporarily in the way. However, in the Deaf community, it is perfectly acceptable and polite to walk between two people having an ASL conversation without signing EXCUSE-ME. Not only is it polite, but to stop and sign EXCUSE-ME or to duck one's head or bend over as one walks by may even be unacceptable because it almost always brings the conversation to a halt and causes an interruption. This is a norm that differs from the norms for spoken-language conversations.

You probably know someone who has been described as being a nice person but who talks too much. The unspoken meaning is that the person always says more than is necessary or talks about things that are not appropriate. The norms here concern quantity and quality of discourse — how much and about what we should talk. Finally, norms dictate what topics can be discussed in which settings. Not all topics are considered suitable for all settings. Some topics are acceptable in public settings, and others are acceptable in private settings. Language users have ways of communicating to each other that the norm is not being followed, that what is being discussed should be addressed at another time. Spoken-language users have ways of talking about private issues in public places (e.g., whispering), and we see examples in ASL, as well. Signers may use reduced forms of signs or sign with one hand in a very reduced signing space. Unfortunately, not much research has been done on this aspect of ASL discourse as yet.

Internal Structure

Discourse has internal structure that comes about in different ways. One way is *turn-taking*. Since everyone in a conversation does not sign at once, signers have different ways to get and keep a turn in conversation. For example, when a person is signing and then comes to the end of a thought, she may pause. If another person in the conversation *self-selects*, that person will take the next turn. If the second person does not self-select, the first person may continue signing or the conversation may end. Another way to get a turn occurs when the first person asks the second person a question, thereby giving the next turn to the second person.

It is important to notice that turn-taking varies depending on the social setting. In a regular conversation, it is usual for conversational partners to self-select unless one person asks a question of another person. In a classroom, however, it is generally the teacher's responsibility to select who gets the next turn; students generally don't self-select. In a courtroom, it is customary that an attorney asks questions of the witness on the stand and the witness answers; witnesses do not usually ask questions.

We also have ways of keeping a turn in conversation once we have gotten it. You will notice in sign conversations that often, if someone tries to interrupt a signer, the signer will lower or avert his eyes and perhaps hold up an index finger or an open hand to indicate that he is not done yet. In fact, as Baker (1977) and other researchers have found, eye gaze is very important in structuring conversations in ASL. Rieger (2001) identified various signs, gestures, and facial expressions used to maintain a turn.

Discourse also may be structured by topic. That is, when a topic is introduced, it controls the flow of a conversation. We may stay on the topic, we may go from general to specific aspects of the topic, we may introduce issues related to the topic, and we may stray from the topic or introduce a new topic. Language has ways of showing how we are dealing with a topic. For example, speakers of English may say, “On a related topic . . .” or “I don’t mean to change the subject, but . . .” to inform others that a change is taking place.

We see examples of structure by topic in ASL. Roy (1989) looked at the structure of a high school science lecture and saw that the teacher used the signs NOW and NOW-THAT to structure his talk. The talk was divided into very clear episodes, and the transitions between the episodes were marked with these signs. In this way, the students watching the lecture were easily able to follow the presentation of the topic and the subtopics. Roy also found that the teacher used *constructed dialogue*, which made the lecture very interesting for the student. Constructed dialogue is used in conversations to tell someone about a conversation that has already taken place — “He said . . .,” “Then I said . . .,” etc. During the constructed dialogue, the signer usually shifts her body and her eye gaze so that it is perfectly clear when she is talking and when the other person is talking. Signers may even report a conversation between two other people and take the role of each by shifting the body and eye gaze.

Hudson suggested that discourse may also be structured by what he calls *encyclopedic knowledge*. That is, the knowledge about a topic that one person brings to a conversation may be very different from the knowledge that another person brings to the conversation. For instance, if you are explaining ASL structure to someone who has no knowledge of it, you will go into much greater detail and have longer turns than if you are explaining it to someone who shares your knowledge. What we know and what we think the other person knows structures our conversations.

Register Variation

The structure of discourse may differ depending on the setting, that is, where and when a conversation takes place. This is known as *register variation*. Register, in this case, means “language appropriate for a certain occasion.” This has traditionally been a very difficult area to describe in any language, but a fairly clear example can be seen by comparing signs used in *informal* and *formal* settings. In informal settings, many two-handed signs may be signed with one hand (COFFEE, TEA, VOTE, PEOPLE, etc.; see Figure 97). In many pairs of signs that have the same meaning, one sign is used in formal settings and the other sign is used in informal settings.

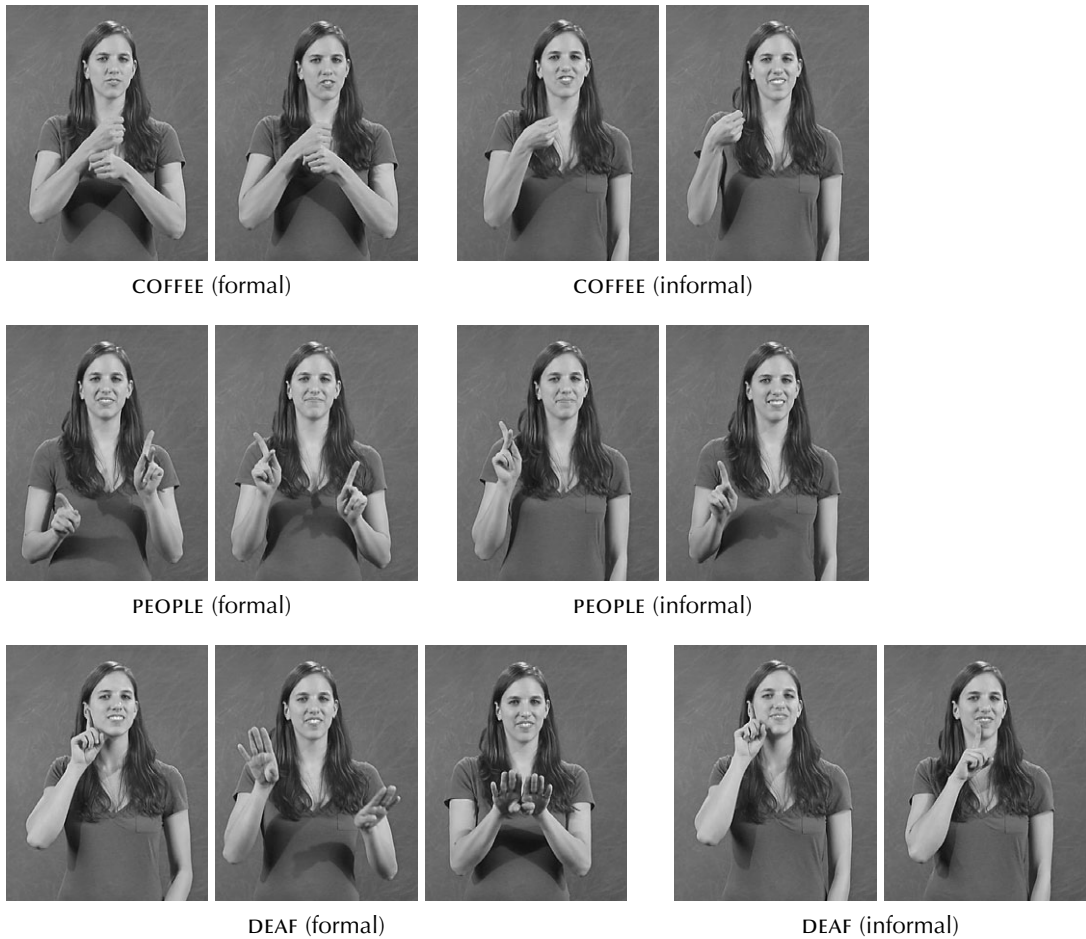


Figure 97. Examples of register variation.

The sign used in informal settings would be totally unacceptable in formal settings. This is true of the two-handed form of *DEAF*, which is used in formal settings, and the form of *DEAF* produced at the ear location.

The location of signs may vary depending on the social setting. In formal settings, the sign *KNOW* may be made on the forehead, while it may be made on the cheek or in the space in front of the signer in informal settings, or it may be a wiggle of the nose. Zimmer (1989) compared one person's signing production in a formal lecture, in a television interview, and in an informal conversation and found that signs used in the informal setting — *PEA-BRAIN*, *WHAT'S-UP*, *KISS-FIST* (“adore”) — did not occur in the formal setting. She saw many rhetorical questions in the lecture but none in the informal and television interview settings. She also found that the signing space in the lecture was much larger than in the other two settings and that the signer used more topicalization in the informal setting than in the formal one. Quinto-Pozos and Mehta (2010) examined gestures used in ASL narratives

and found that differences in production depended on whether the narratives were signed in formal or informal settings.

LANGUAGE AS A SIGNAL OF SOCIAL IDENTITY

The final area of discourse is language used as a signal of social identity. A good example from English is the use of first names as opposed to a title with a last name. Do we call someone we have just met “Dr. Wilson” or “John”? And if we start out calling someone Dr. Wilson, how do we know when it is acceptable to start calling him by his first name? The use of a first name or a title with a last name indicates the social identity of both the speaker and the person being spoken to. It reveals the social relationship between the two people.

If you have studied Spanish, French, Italian, German, or other languages, you know that many languages have complex ways of showing social relationships through pronouns. These languages have pronouns for formal situations and pronouns for informal situations. The pronouns used by a supervisor and an employee may be different from those used between friends. Not very much is known about how ASL or other sign languages signal social identity, but this is a fruitful area for future research. Think about your own use of ASL: Do you use first names and names with titles in your conversations, as spoken languages do? How do you signal that you are a student and that you are talking to a boss or a professor? Do you sign differently with a good friend than with a teacher?

NEW AREAS OF RESEARCH

In recent years, the analysis of ASL discourse has focused on a variety of areas, including the use of nonmanual signals such as eye gaze and mouthing (Bahan and Supalla 1995; Bridges and Metzger 1996; Hoza, 2008) and the use of space for reference (Emmorey 1999; Emmorey and Reilly 1995; van Hoek 1996; Winston 1993, 1999). Studies also include the analysis of parent-child discourse (Volterra and Erting 1994), interpreted discourse (Metzger 1995; Roy 1996), and classroom discourse (Smith and Ramsey 2004).

Mulrooney (2009) examined ASL personal narratives and found that signers use a consistent structure to organize spontaneously produced narratives. This structure consists of six possible parts: an introduction identifying the topic of the narrative, background information about the events, the main events describing what happened, explication of the most significant event, reflection on the events, and a closing. This research used features not traditionally incorporated into a narrative analysis, including eye gaze, body postures, facial expressions, gestures, and partial demonstrations of actions. Mulrooney argues that these features are critical to an effective analysis of ASL. Her findings align with other research about space and gesturing in ASL that may provide important information about spoken language discourse as well (Taub, Galvan, Pilar 2009).

SUPPLEMENTAL READING

"Discourse Analysis," by Melanie Metzger and Ben Bahan (2001); pp. 516–541

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Homework Assignment 19

1. You are walking along and you see a group of your friends talking. You want to join the conversation. Think about and describe how you enter the group and how you get a turn to talk. What signs do you use? What about eye gaze? What is the correct way to enter a conversation and what is the “wrong” way?
2. What do you do in an ASL conversation when you want to change the topic? What signs do you use? Is there a particular way to change the subject?
3. Make a list of five signs that are signed differently in formal and informal situations, and describe how they differ. For example, KNOW may differ depending on the setting.
4. Watch a conversation from the Kansas or Louisiana segments of the DVD. Identify what signers do to indicate they want to take the floor. Identify the ways a signer keeps the floor when someone else attempts to interrupt.

“Louisiana Conversation.” From the NSF Sociolinguistic Variation Project conducted at Gallaudet University, 1994–2001.

“My Favorite Old Summer House,” signed by Clayton Valli, from Clayton Valli, *Poetry in Motion: Original Works in ASL* (Burtonsville, MD: Sign Media Inc., 1990). Used by permission.

“Dandelions,” signed by Clayton Valli, from Clayton Valli, *Poetry in Motion: Original Works in ASL* (Burtonsville, MD: Sign Media Inc., 1990). Used by permission.

The DVD content is available online on the Gallaudet University Press YouTube channel: **[youtube.com/GallaudetUniversityPress](https://www.youtube.com/GallaudetUniversityPress)**.

Under Playlists, click "Linguistics of American Sign Language (5th edition) DVD."